



The Llanos

A huge expanse of savanna plains, transformed by seasonal flooding and supporting a unique collection of animals



N. South
America

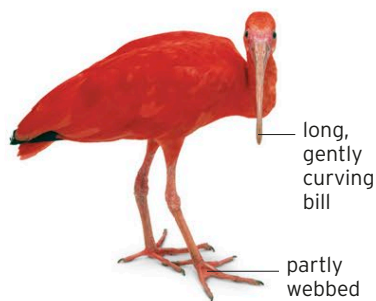
△ WATCHFUL EYE

There are more than 100 species of reptiles living in the Llanos, including many different turtles, snakes, and crocodilians. One of the most abundant is the spectacled caiman.

The Llanos, or “Plains,” is a sprawling tropical grassland region, stretching across Colombia and Venezuela from the foothills of the Andes to the Orinoco Delta, where it meets the Caribbean. Although the Llanos contains a mosaic of different habitats, including woodland and swamps, most is treeless savanna, which is subject to seasonal flooding by the Orinoco River’s tributaries.

Unique wildlife

The Llanos is home to many species not typically found in savanna ecosystems. These include the critically endangered Orinoco crocodile, which is only found in the Llanos, and the largest rodent in the world, the semiaquatic capybara. The region supports several hundred species of birds—both residents and migrants—with a large proportion of waterfowl and waders.



△ DISTINCTIVE BILL

The Llanos contains the world’s largest population of scarlet ibis. The bird uses its long, thin bill to probe for food such as insects in soft mud and under plants.

SEASONAL FLOODING

The Llanos is a region of climatic extremes with seasonal flooding and droughts. More than 90 percent of its annual rainfall occurs between April and October. By May, the tributaries of the Orinoco have started to overflow, and at the height of the season much of the Llanos is wetland.



MAY

JUNE

OCTOBER

The Llanos is home to the **world’s most powerful snake**, the green anaconda